

Text and shoot with same controller

Hyperkin PS3 Remotext to be unveiled at E3 will combined the functionality of a PS3 controller with a QWERTY keypad

3DS sales not upto the mark

Nintendo 3DS may have created a buzz on its launch, but according to GameStop, the sales are slowing down below expectations



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Most people, including those who game a lot, have a few misconceptions about gaming gear in general. First of all buying gaming gear certainly won't make you a pro overnight but like I've said earlier, switching to good equipment improves your performance by a lot. Let me do a quick 101 session on gaming mice here and tell you what you need to look for when going in for this specialised category of geek weapon.

Which mouse to opt for depends a lot on the type of grip you use. There are a couple of grips that gamers use, namely the palm grip, claw grip, and the fingertip grip. The palm grip is the simplest way most people instinctively hold a mouse – laying your palm in full contact with the curvature of the mouse. For this grip a mouse that's nice and thick works best (like high-end Logitech's). In the Claw grip you hold the mouse pretty much like the palm grip except you tend to arch your fingers like forming a claw - hence the name. As for contact, it's a little lesser than the palm grip, but you still tend to stabilise the mouse with the back of your palm. If you're a claw gamer, you will do well with a mouse that's nice and ground-hugging (like most Razer mice). A mouse that's stable but not too thick works best because arching fingers over a thick mouse as you can imagine, gets a little difficult. The last one is the Fingertip grip. This one



Point and shoot

Agent 001 takes up the challenge of pointing you in the right direction

involves the least contact. Here the entire mouse is held with just the tips of the fingers.

The funny thing however is that as the intensity of the game changes, players tend to change their grip accordingly. Once you observe your gaming grip style, you can zero in on the style that you use most often and then choose. The other important aspects to look at include customisation. Some mouse models allow this by adding weights and switchable bodies (eg. G9 Gaming mouse from Logitech). There are also buttons that switch DPI sensitivity on the fly. Gamers appreciate this feature. Rounding off other features of note I can speak of programmable macro buttons – good for MMOs and strategy games – internal memory for storing profiles and a good software UI. The bulk of the mouse is also important. The Digit guys tell me that they've recently got a gaming mouse from CoolerMaster called Spawn that has a smaller footprint, which is good for slim and trim people like me, Will try it out the next time I go down to the Digit Test Centre. And now onward to my shopping experience.

I went to a couple of hardware vendors locally to check out what was available. The first vendor that I went to showed me a few local brands. When I asked the person at the counter for something a bit more upmarket, I was told that I could get a Logitech MX 518 or a Razer Deathadder.

This was about the best shop I could find. Some of the other guys just didn't keep Razer stuff, and the higher



end Logitech stuff was not available. I was thinking of upgrading from my MX 518, but I couldn't find anyone who could advise me, or anyone who even had the patience to listen to what I needed.

Call me paranoid, for there is no clinical evidence to support this, but I find Razer mice to be a little flimsy – the left and right click buttons being the culprits. I've used a couple of Razer mice, and have found these keys dying within 18 months of buying them. First the click becomes softer, then the keys work but the "clicking" sound ceases and then boom. Logitech mice on the other hand refuse to die. Even my four-year old MX 518 still works fine, although the left click gets stuck every 3 weeks or so. There is a dearth of good brands in India, but the situation is much better than what it was a year back, with Steelseries and Roccat coming to India. Even with my trepidation over Razers longevity, I couldn't help fall in love with the Razer Emperor.

Maybe it was the name, maybe it was the sexy in-hand fit, but the Emperor fitted my hand well. Of course, the Mamba with its larger side buttons felt even better, but it was selling for over 6000 bucks – no way I was going to spend that much, especially since I didn't want a wireless mouse, and the Mamba can work both wired and wirelessly – no sense paying for a feature I won't use. I really wanted the Emperor, but for 3,500 bucks I could also pick up a Logitech G500. Now the G500 is a good mouse, with the added benefit of free and ratchet scrolling, and of course a tilting mouse-wheel – great for spreadsheets. For me, the dealmaker was the reliability factor, and the G500 it was. 